1833 to take up the first chair in Sanskrit at Oxford, began to translate the *R-V* into English he was astonished to find references to the killing and eating of cattle. For example, in Wilson's pioneering translation *R-V* 10.86.14 reads: 'The worshippers dress for me fifteen (and) twenty bulls: I eat them and (become) fat, they fill both sides of my belly.'

Since Wilson's time scores of Sanskritists, from Wilson's protégé Rajendralal Mitra all the way down through the generations to the present distinguished (and much vilified) historian D. N. Jha, author of *The Myth of the Holy Cow* (2001), have come to the same inescapable conclusion: that the *Vedas* contain frequent references to the sacrifice and eating of cattle. As that well-known historian the late D. D. Kosambi put it: 'Vedic Brahmins had fattened upon a steady diet of sacrificed beef'.[18]

Conversely, I can find no dogs portrayed on Harappan seals.[19] The domesticated dog, *Canis familiaris*, is believed to have first established links with hunters in central Eurasia some twenty-five thousand years ago. The *R-V* tells us that the Arya saw dogs as companions and protectors.[20] So when, for example, the god Indra has some cattle stolen, he is helped to find them by a female spirit of the clouds named Sarama, also known as *devashuni*, 'the divine bitch'. She is the mother of all dogs and gives birth to two four-eyed brindle dogs, who become the watch-dogs of the god of death, Yama.[21]

Snakes are absent from the *R-V* other than an evil python-like creature called Vritra, 'the squeezer', the personification of drought and the opponent of the rain-bearing god Indra. But this Vritra is also described as a *dasa*, the pejorative epithet that came to be applied by the Arya to the non-Arya people of the Indian plains. If the Arya of the *R-V* had never seen a snake, imagine what terror a first encounter with a 3-metre-long King Cobra must have inspired. I can remember as a child seeing one of these fearsome reptiles – black with